

Instructor Guide — Lesson 7: Build Your 90-Day Opportunity Plan

Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path
- **Course:** Course 18 — Professional Presence & Opportunity Building
- **Lesson:** 7 of 8 — Build Your 90-Day Opportunity Plan
- **Age range:** 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led (video classroom)
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tools needed:** Google Docs (plan document), content-planning tool already used in L4/L5 (e.g., a simple content calendar — spreadsheet or planner app)
- **Prerequisite state:** Student has an established professional presence (L1–3), at least one content piece drafted or published with more in progress (L4), presence extended across broader channels (L5), and outreach/networking activity started — at least one message sent or contact made (L6)
- **Lesson position in course arc:** This is the synthesis lesson. Everything built in L1–6 gets converted into a forward-looking, dated plan. L8 will likely be a review/showcase, so this is the last lesson where new planning work happens.

Overview

Students have spent six lessons building pieces: a presence, content, channels, and early networking contacts. Those pieces are real but scattered in time — a profile here, a draft there, one message sent last week. This lesson has students convert that scattered work into a single **90-day plan** broken into three monthly blocks, each with a content cadence, networking touchpoints, and one or two concrete opportunity goals. The plan is realistic on purpose: paced for a teenager's actual weekly schedule (school, homework, other activities), not an idealized burst of activity.

The instructional bet here is pacing over ambition. Most students at this age either want to do everything in week one and burn out, or treat "make a plan" as a one-time abstract exercise disconnected from real dates. This lesson corrects both by making the plan concrete, dated, and checkable.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Break a 90-day goal into three monthly blocks with specific, dated actions.
2. Set a realistic content cadence (roughly one piece every 2–3 weeks, five pieces total) instead of an unsustainable burst.
3. Define networking touchpoints as a repeatable monthly habit, not a one-off task.
4. Write one or two opportunity goals that are concrete and checkable ("apply to X by date," "publish 2 more pieces"), not vague ("get better at coding" or "become successful").
5. Identify a way to know whether each goal was actually completed.

Prep Checklist (before class)

- Open a blank Google Doc titled "90-Day Opportunity Plan — Demo" for the live build.
- Have the Worksheet.md template ready to share/screen-share.
- Review each student's L4–L6 artifacts if accessible (content drafts, channel list, outreach log) so you can reference their real work during the plan-building activity — this lesson lands much better when tied to what a student already did, not hypothetical work.
- Prepare the fictional student example ("Jordan R.") talking points below so the live demo is fluent, not read verbatim.
- Have today's actual date on screen so month blocks can be dated live (e.g., "Month 1 = Sept 12–Oct 12").

Teaching Sequence (60 minutes)

1. Opening + Framing (5 min)

Ask: "What's one piece of content or one networking thing you did in the last two weeks?" Take 2–3 quick answers. Frame the lesson: "Today we're not creating anything new — we're taking everything from the last six lessons and putting it on a calendar so it actually keeps happening."

2. Talking Points: Why Pacing Matters (8 min)

Deliver these points directly, not as a slide dump — talk through them:

- **Small and consistent beats big and sporadic.** One piece of content every 2–3 weeks for three months is five real, finished pieces. One "content sprint weekend" that burns you out produces two pieces and then nothing for two months.
- **A 90-day plan is not a cage.** Having a plan doesn't mean nothing can change — it means you have a default so you're not starting from zero every week deciding what to do. If an opportunity comes up that isn't on the plan, you can still take it. The plan is a floor, not a ceiling.
- **Networking touchpoints are a habit, not an event.** One outreach message a month, every month, for three months, builds a small real network. Reaching out to 15 people in one week and then never following up builds nothing — most of those contacts go cold.

- **Realistic means it fits around school.** A plan that assumes 2 hours a day of free time is not a plan a 16-year-old with homework, sports, and a life will follow. Ask what a student can actually do in a normal week, not their best week.

3. Live Demo: Building Jordan's 90-Day Plan (20 min)

Build this live in the Google Doc, narrating decisions out loud. Use a fictional student, "Jordan R.," a rising junior who wants to break into game development and has: a portfolio site (L1–3), one finished blog post and one half-finished project writeup (L4), a presence on a game-dev forum and a Discord server (L5), and one cold email sent to an indie developer with no reply yet (L6).

Month 1 (Days 1–30): - Content goal: Finish and publish the half-finished project writeup (Week 2). Start a new short piece — "what I learned building X" (draft by Week 4). - Networking goal: Reply-follow-up to the indie developer if no response by Day 10; introduce self in the Discord server's intro channel (Week 1); reply meaningfully to 2 threads on the forum (ongoing). - Opportunity goal: Identify one game jam or student competition with a deadline in the next 90 days and register/bookmark it by end of month. - How Jordan will know: writeup is live at a URL; one new Discord/forum interaction logged each week; competition name and deadline written down.

Month 2 (Days 31–60): - Content goal: Publish the short piece drafted in Month 1 (Week 5–6). Start piece #3 — a short devlog about jam progress if entered, or a tutorial if not. - Networking goal: Reach out to 2 new contacts (a teacher, a local dev meetup organizer, or someone active in the Discord) — one message each, spaced out, not both in one day. - Opportunity goal: Submit an entry or application for the competition identified in Month 1, OR complete 50% of the jam project. - How Jordan will know: piece #2 published; 2 new outreach messages sent and logged with dates; submission confirmation email or draft entry saved.

Month 3 (Days 61–90): - Content goal: Finish and publish piece #3 (Week 9–10). Publish piece #4/#5 if pace allows — total of 5 pieces across the 90 days is the target, not 3. - Networking goal: Follow up with the 2 new contacts from Month 2; one more new outreach message. - Opportunity goal: Complete and submit the competition/jam entry if not already done in Month 2; reflect in writing on what came of the outreach (replies, no replies, next steps). - How Jordan will know: final piece count reaches 5; outreach log shows 3+ new contacts total across 90 days; competition entry submitted with confirmation.

While building this, stop twice to ask the class: "Is this too much for one month? Too little?" and adjust live — this models that the plan is a draft, not a contract.

4. Discussion Questions (5 min)

- "Jordan's content cadence was one piece every 2–3 weeks. Is that realistic for you, or does your schedule need something slower or faster?"
- "What's one networking touchpoint you could actually repeat every month without it feeling exhausting?"
- "What's one opportunity — a competition, program, internship, or job — that has a real deadline in the next 90 days?"

5. Guided Activity: Students Build Their Own Plan (18 min)

Students open the Worksheet.md (as a Google Doc or their planning tool) and fill in their own 3-month table using their real L1–6 work as the starting point. Circulate to check in 1:1 or in breakout pairs. Prompt students who freeze on "opportunity goal" with: "What's one specific thing — an application, a submission, a competition, a request — you could point to on day 90 and say 'I did that?'"

6. Close (4 min)

Have 2–3 students share one goal from their plan out loud. Remind them: the plan gets checked in on (suggest a monthly self-check date), and it's fine to revise it — the point is having a default, not being locked in.

Common Misconceptions (address explicitly during talking points or activity)

- **"I need to do everything at once."** Correct with the small-and-consistent point above. If a student's Month 1 has 4 content pieces and 5 outreach messages, that's a sign to redistribute across the 90 days, not to admire their ambition.
- **"A plan means nothing can change."** Correct with the "floor, not ceiling" framing. A plan is a default so you're not starting from scratch, not a contract that forbids new opportunities.
- **"Networking touchpoint" means a big ask.** Some students think every networking action has to be a formal request. Reinforce that a touchpoint can be small — a comment, a reply, a short check-in message.
- **"Opportunity goal" is the same as "keep doing content."** Students sometimes just restate their content goal as the opportunity goal. Push for something distinct and checkable — an application, submission, competition entry, or specific ask.

Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What it looks like	Fix
Overloads Month 1	Plans 5+ actions crammed into the first 30 days	Ask "what happens in a normal school week with homework?" and move items to Month 2/3
Vague opportunity goal	Writes "get noticed" or "improve skills"	Ask "what's the specific thing — a form, a deadline, a person — that this points to?"
No real opportunity identified	Can't name a competition/program/internship	Give 2–3 generic examples appropriate to their interest area (school science fair, open-source contribution, student hackathon, local business asking for help, a relevant online competition) and let them adapt
Can't state "how I'll know"	Leaves that column blank or restates the goal	Ask "if I looked at your evidence 90 days from now, what would I actually see — a link, a screenshot, an email?"
Treats plan as rigid	Says "but what if I get a better idea in month 2?"	Reassure: revise it then — the written plan is today's best guess, not a lock

How to Review Student Work

Check each submitted plan for: 1. Three distinct monthly blocks, each with dated or week-numbered actions. 2. A content cadence that totals roughly 5 pieces across 90 days (not fewer than 3, not an unrealistic 10+). 3. At least one networking touchpoint per month, phrased as a repeatable or specific action (not "network more"). 4. One or two opportunity goals that are concrete and named (a specific competition, application, or submission) with a rough target date. 5. A "how I'll know" statement for each goal that names actual evidence (a link, a log entry, a confirmation).

Plans missing item 4 or 5 are the most common gap — give feedback there first.

Lesson Close / Transition to Next Lesson

End by telling students their plan is now their default calendar for the next 3 months, and that Lesson 8 will look back at what they've built across the whole course. Encourage them to put a recurring monthly reminder (phone, calendar) to check the plan against what actually happened.